

The Crossroads

Jan - Feb 2024

Issue 14

#CIRS Impact 1.0
- Editorial Team

Character Development
Through Sports

The Editorial - Anant Varma



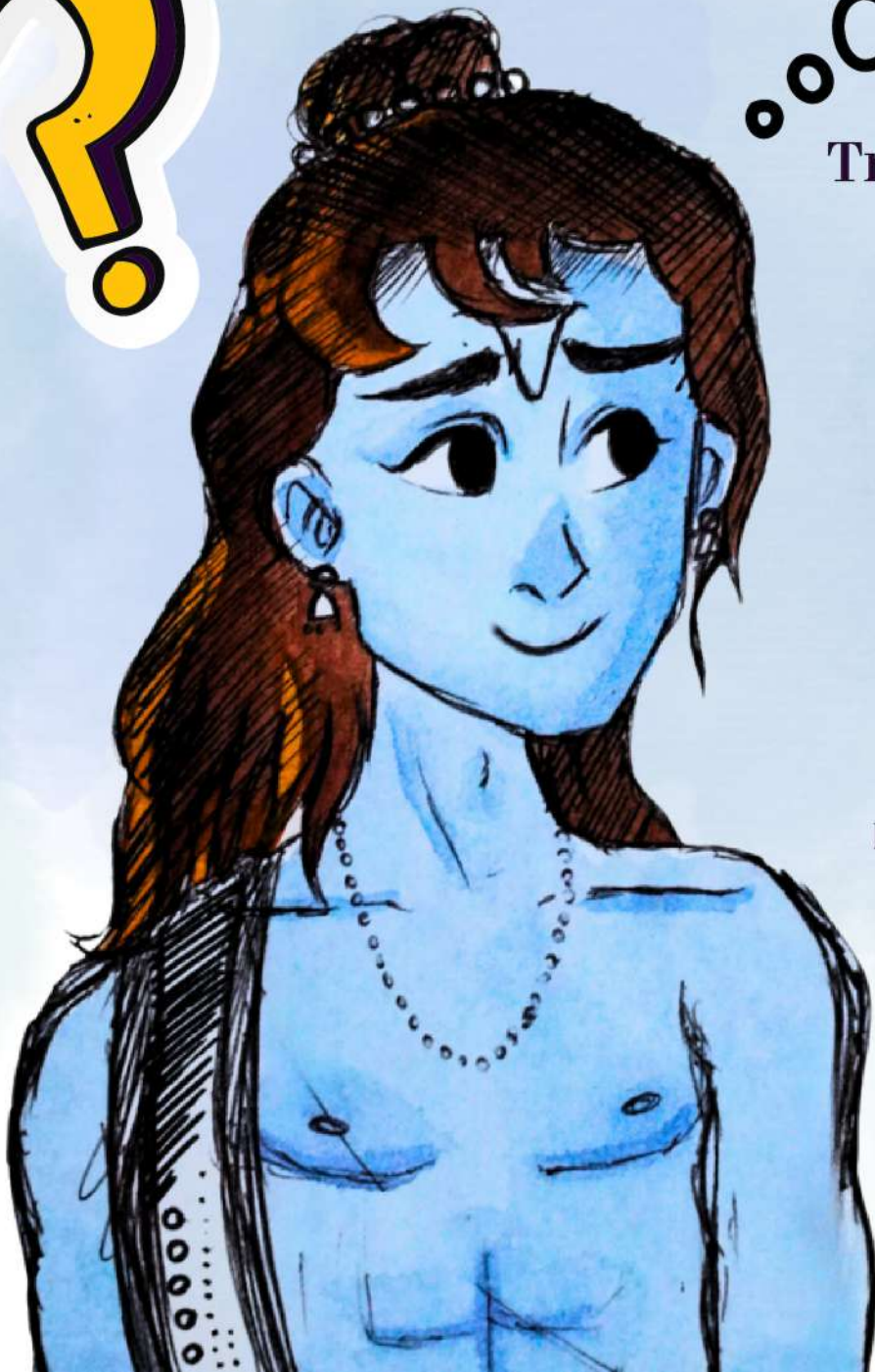
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CHARACTER DEVELOPMENT THROUGH SPORTS



- The Editorial

There is always a pair in the world wherein one without the other would just exist without any certain objective to fulfil. For example, a pencil and an eraser, socks and shoes, curd and sugar and so on. Analogously, a 'complete' life would cease to exist without sports.



For growing children, sport proves itself to be an integral part of their lives as they learn to become physically and mentally tough, enabling them to retaliate in the face of any adversities they may encounter. Sports shapes one's personality and develops communication skills. A sportsperson learns to let go of desires that are centred around triumph, and starts admiring the beauty of the lessons learned through defeat.

With the right coaching, a person learns to appreciate sportsmanship and inculcates the virtue of fairness on and off the field.

It's appalling to see the number of modern youth neglecting sporting events, and instead, spending hours choosing the perfect emojis to respond to a text message. The characteristics of a successful and well-trained sportsperson can be recognised through his habit of always putting others before himself; and also through his respectful behaviour towards others.



Let us look at an example - Ravi and Shyam are very close friends. Ravi gets selected for the school's football team and is very excited to tell Shyam all about it. Not being selected in the team, Shyam develops intense jealousy towards Ravi, even though Ravi had promised to help Shyam in making it into the team at the next tryouts. In this case, Ravi is a true sportsperson who is looking forward to grabbing this opportunity and improving his skills in order to help his friend Shyam. But Shyam, being blind to learning through sports, will be forever ignorant of the benefits he has is missing out on.

A true sportsman learns to see that there is more to a game than just scoring points and performing better than other players. He learns to welcome all opportunities to learn from his teammates and opponents. Playing to unlock the capabilities lacking in him and channelling these newfound abilities to respect the players and the game becomes his purpose. Despite losses, a true sportsman's perspective of the game's purpose does not get hindered. Aspire to be a true sportsman and make a difference in the world and the ones around you.



01 **Amazing Discovery - 3000 year old ancient cities discovered in Amazon Rainforest! Have Houses, roads, plaza & more**



Archaeologists have made a groundbreaking discovery in the Amazon Rainforests, revealing the most extensive network of pre-Hispanic urban settlements ever found. The discovery has uncovered evidence of a lost civilization dating back 2000 years. The settlements, covering an area of 1000 SqKM, were hidden by the dense Ecuador valley foothills of the Andes. The settlements comprised of 20 distinct areas featuring large straight streets and central alleys, resembling the layout of the Teotihuacan city.

02 **Architecture - India's longest sea-bridge 'Atal Setu' opens in Mumbai : Built at a cost of 21,000 Crore.**



India's longest sea bridge covering 21.8 km out of which 16.5 km is over the sea, is expected to see the movement of more than 70,000 vehicles every day. "The inauguration of Atal Setu shows India's infrastructural prowess and underscores the country's trajectory towards a 'Viksit Bharat'. This project employed around 17,000 labourers and 1,500 engineers while also creating employment opportunities in the transport and construction industries."- Prime Minister Narendra Modi

03 **Taste of India - Masala Chai named second best non-alcoholic drink in the world, Mexico's Aguas Frescas ranks top.**

Stop the press! Masala chai just hit the jackpot! In 2023, it snagged the runner-up award for the world's most sippable non-alcoholic drink. Taste Atlas, the all-knowing guide to global grub, unveiled their list of the world's favorite booze-free bevies, and whoop whoop, masala chai took the crown in the Best Foods and Drinks in India category. Move over, juice cleanses; chai is the new healthy sip!



04 **Unique Photos from Around the World.**



A young Non-Resident Indian paying homage in the snow to a Shiv Lingam that she handcrafted in the USA.



Indian Students along with their western peers enjoying an evening of Garba in the United Kingdom. Garba has been classified as an Intangible Cultural heritage.



Australian Hindus Celebrating Indian Culture, connecting with the positive practices of India through our timeless celebrations.

01

Ramayana *Thus, It Happened*

- Raghav Agrawal

SOURCED: LIFE - AN ARADHANA IO

The long-awaited Ram Mandir at Ayodhya has finally been inaugurated at the birthplace of Bhagavan Shri Ram, and the gates are already flooding with devotees. This sacred land has now been legally classified as the original birthplace of Shri Ram.

Now here's the issue; despite being great devotees and believers, we often doubt whether the Ramayana actually took place or not; whether the Man of Perfection lived or was he just a myth. But do not worry, I will clear all your doubts. However, before we delve into proving the historicity of the Ramayana, it is important to know that these doubts started arising only during periods of colonisation by foreign civilisations. Invaders always sought ways to disprove our glorious past and demean our heritage. With that being said, let us begin.



In today's modern era, the only kind of evidence we give any importance to is archaeological evidence. We need to consider the fact that the more distant in the past that the event under investigation is, the greater the difficulty faced in finding the archaeological evidence. But there are various other ways besides archaeology of confirming the occurrence of an event.

Beginning at the most basic level, everything that we know about Shri Ram and his life originates from the Valmiki Ramayana - the oldest and most credible account, composed by Sage Valmiki himself. However, it has been engraved in our minds that the Ramayana is 'mythological', which might as well be the same for Sage Valmiki. We need to know that it was the colonisers who classified it as mythological. In our scriptures, it is actually classified as 'Itihasa', a Sanskrit term that literally translates to 'Thus, it happened'. This solidifies the fact that our culture has always considered Ramayana as its history.



Here, the question arises; "Ramayana has many unrealistic exaggerations which practically imply that the Ramayana could not have occurred, then how can it be accepted?"

In order to understand this, let us apply a simple analogy - Every movie inspired by true events has its own exaggerations and embellishments, which are natural aspects of poetry in the form of metaphors. One who has studied the same in Sanskrit literature is able to differentiate between facts and stories. Hence, it could very well be the same for Sage Valmiki's classic. Over centuries and across regions, the narrative of the Ramayana has been extremely consistent with only slightly localised versions; none of which depict Shri Ram as a fictional character.

The Ramayana has also been cross-referenced in numerous historical scriptures like the Vedas, Puranas and Raghu Vamsa. Even the ancient texts of Tamil literature speak of Shri Ram and the Ram Setu with pride. In his travelogue, Al-Beruni in the 11th century had written that Shri Ram had built the bridge to Lanka. The Buddhist monk Kumaralata also talks about the public recitation of the Ramayana in the 2nd century.

The Ramayana elaborately describes the Sarasvati as a mighty river, whose past existence has been proven by satellite mapping. It's been established that this great river started diminishing only around 4500 BCE and completely dried up around 2500 BCE. Moreover, The Valmiki Ramayana also has over 500 astronomical references, specifically given to indicate the time of the significant events.

Interestingly, King Sugriva had also described the geography and mileposts from India through Peru and Chile! In his instructions to the search parties, he clearly mentions the famous Candelabra in the Andes, the Arctic-Antarctic regions as "filled with ice" and the North pole region as "dark, but lit up", referring to the Aurora Borealis.



Cities like Ayodhya, Kishkindha and Srngaverapura exist till date in the exact locations as pointed out in the Ramayana. The epic has described many places by listing its flora and fauna, which exist today as well; Dandaka, Kishkindha and Panchavati are some more of the many examples that still prevail.

For further information, for those who are still sceptical, Vanaras were not actually monkeys, but vananaras or the forest people, carrying the monkey as their totem. Kishkindha, where Hanuman and Jambhavan lived, still has the unique combination of monkeys and bears in its forests.

Even the Supreme Court of India has considered all the evidence and unbroken traditions that generations of people have kept alive and declared that the Ram Janma Bhoomi at Ayodhya is indeed where the temple of Shri Ram should be built. With all this being said, we can truly conclude... Thus, it happened!

02 *Is Tolerance Respect?*

- Rishi Suresh Iyer

Today, I want to talk about something that in my short 17 years on this planet, has felt both incredibly simple and frustratingly complex- Religious Tolerance.

See, I grew up in a world where diversity was the norm. My school hallway reverberated with a myriad of languages, my lunch table a mosaic of traditions, my classroom a confluence of cultures. Yet, even amidst this richness, I overheard whispers of judgment, lines drawn based on the way someone prayed or the stories they held sacred. And it left me wondering: Why?

Why, when the sun paints the sky in a thousand hues, do we insist on seeing the world as drab and disgusting in the monochrome of black and white, labelling beliefs as either "good" or "bad"? Is it our compulsive need for order, the inherent necessity for clear-cut categories to navigate the messy perceptions of human experience?

Think about it. Is the sunrise any less magnificent because I offer water and prayers to it while you picture the beauty of Hydrogen atoms colliding? Does a prayer whispered in the walls of Tirupati hold less power than a hymn sung in Mecca? Does my expression of love undermine yours because of its language? How can we call something good or bad without understanding it's place in the big picture?

Opposing philosophies often label each other as Good and Bad, thereby leading to the popular notion that 'Religion divides humanity'. However, our perceptions of 'good' and 'bad' in this context are quite flimsy. Context is the key, what resonates with me might seem alien to you. Religion therefore, has no character of good or bad to cause any divide. You and me differ based on thoughts. Well, that's okay! In fact, it's beautiful!

Differences are a good thing, but sometimes people struggle to accept them. This discomfort often stems from how we see and handle diversity. This can create tension, especially in cultural and religious contexts, leading to the popular notion of "Religious Tolerance." Tolerance is defined in the Oxford Dictionary as the ability to tolerate opinions or behaviors we dislike or do not completely accept.

If you were to go out for lunch with friends, would you be ok with being tolerated at the table? Throughout the 20th Century, were the Africans ok to be tolerated by Whites? Would Bharat have freedom today, if our freedom fighters were ok being tolerated by the British? No. To all of these questions, the answer will always be NO. Then, why should my religious practices be merely 'tolerated' by the practitioner of another religion?

Tolerance only enters the equation when the assertion of superiority arrives. The thought of superiority breeds tolerance. The thought of equality births respect. The thought is what shows whether it is good or bad.



From a certain perspective, Tolerance appears to do a world of good, creating an almost utopian existence of no strife and conflict where we all live and breathe as one people, but then, how long can we ignore the undercurrents of enmity which stem from the lack of acceptance and a feeling of superiority? Seen from its own stand point Tolerance seems to be good, while seen from the standpoint of respect, tolerance as a virtue leaves much to be desired.

At the table of religion, with diverging philosophies, Bharatiya traditions manage to bring true oneness in thought. The idea is that differences are not bones to pick but rather an aid to foster a vibrant exchange of perspectives. They interweave the stories of each individual, threading together the fabric of humanity. As evidenced by the world famous depiction of the Samudra Manthan in the Bharatiya Itihasa which shows a vibrant work ethic against the backdrop of Mutual Respect amidst differences.

Unravelling this fabric, we can choose to either knot the strands and let divisiveness prevail. Or we can choose to care for each thread individually giving each one the same care as the other, leading to cohesive existence. The process is the same, only the perspective leads to drastically different outcomes. Why! Even Respect becomes toxic when it isn't mutual. This gives us a very clear idea that there is indeed no good or bad, it is only our thinking which makes it so.

Open your hearts and minds to the stories of others. Mutual respect means acknowledging that your perspective isn't the only perspective. Good and bad are subjective, shaped by perception. Everyone has a unique journey; whether it's Martin Luther King Jr. or Mahatma Gandhi, their stories inspire billions. Our paths may differ, but the quest for something larger than ourselves unites us all regardless of the symbols we use to represent them.

03 *Ramayana*

The Tale Continues

- Global CHYK Team

In the heart of Chinmaya International Residential School, Coimbatore, on December 17th, 2023, more than 100 CHYKs eagerly gathered for the 16th Annual Global CHYK Camp (GCC). The camp was a continuation of the previous Global CHYK Camp 2022, and hence named Ramayana - The Tale Continues. Over the next eight days, Our CHYKs embarked on a journey of transformative spiritual growth, fostering deep connections, embracing peace, and indulging in the sheer joy of the spiritual experience.



From the very outset, we delved into the thrilling tale of the Ramcharitramanas by Shri.Tulsidas ji, commencing with Aranyakanda - The Forest Episode. The poetic verses of Tulsidas ji coupled with the inspiring insights and masterful weaving of stories by Swami Swaroopananda ji evoked laughter, introspection, and wonder. It was also not uncommon to see a camper's eyes brimming with tears with the sheer intensity and emotion hidden within the depths of the various episodes.

Engaging discussion sessions led by Swami Anukoolananda ji on the authenticity and historicity of the Ramayana based on Valmiki ji's original tale and introspective sessions by Swamini Supriyananda ji, coupled with the ever welcoming enchanting natural beauty of the CIRS campus, prompted personal reflections on embodying unwavering faith akin to mountains, the tranquillity of lakes, and the abundant growth of spiritual gardens in our own personal spiritual quest.

Our exploration continued into Kishkinda Kanda and Sundara Kanda, where the radiant light of Shri Hanuman ji illuminated the intricacies of Dharma. Every session was accompanied by captivating activity sessions featuring balance beams, team strength tests, and mind-bending word games. We learned the strength, balance, and discerning intellect that propelled Hanuman on his quest for Sita.



The concluding days were dedicated to Lanka Kanda, urging us to reflect on the internal battles and cultivate the 'Shield of Dispassion' and the 'Sword of Contentment' to conquer our negative tendencies. Rigorous tests of these qualities unfolded through a survival challenge and a Capture the Flag war game, offering both challenge and immense exhilaration.

The discussion groups led by the Brahmacharins, Brahmacharinis and senior CHYKs helped us delve into the deepest depths of our personality, challenging preconceived notions and giving birth to empowering revelations. The knowledge gained during the course of the camp was further cemented into our consciousness through the soulful bhajans and songs which served as divine interludes to our daily sessions.

In essence, GCC has bestowed upon us, enduring friendships, forged through enchanting evening performances, bonding activities, insightful discussions, and delicious food. Yet, the most treasured gift from the Acharyas and the GCC team is the spirit of pure Bhakti, selflessness, and love—a flame we are eager to share with others throughout our lives.

Economic Impact of Ram Mandir

- Yash Baisya



A sprawling city of 875 sq. km. A mammoth ₹85,000 crore makeover. 37 national and state agencies investing another ₹31,662 crores. A four-fold increase in land prices. All of this, in just 4 years.

Welcome to the aftermath of Ram's return to Ayodhya in 2024. From tourism to FMCGs, from MSMEs to MNCs, every single industry has washed its hands in the flow of profit from the holy land on the banks of the Sarayu. While Coca-Cola, the world's most valuable non-alcoholic beverage brand, changed its traditional red colour



branding to darker shades in line with the temple theme in over 50 retail outlets, Pakka Ltd., an Ayodhya-based regenerative packaging materials company has seen their share value on the NSE surge over 150% since January. Ram's grace has been ubiquitous, benefiting everyone who has landed in the lands of Ayodhya.

First, the most obvious boon has been the increase in religious tourism. Data by the UP Tourism Department shows that while 3,25,000 tourists visited Ayodhya in 2021, the number surged to 2.3 crores the following year. Expected to attract more than 5 crore tourists a year after the inauguration, it also is expected to lead to an increased demand for both domestic and international connectivity from which aviation, railways and ancillary service providers are set to gain. The NHAI has already announced investments worth ₹10,000 crores to develop the region. Be it the hefty capital outlay of 5-star players such as Taj, Radisson and ITC, or the addition of over 1000 hotel rooms by budget players like OYO, the land has witnessed an expected rise in the hotel and hospitality sector. A mega tourist city of such global standards will attract lakhs of tourists daily, and is bound to revolutionise the economy of more than a dozen neighbouring districts.



As per estimates, the city, after the full completion of the Ram Mandir and redevelopment, is likely to have a 1:10 ratio of residents to tourists. This will unlock new business opportunities. Residents have seen their land prices within a 5-10 km radius of the temple rise from ₹2,000/sq ft. to as high as ₹18,000/sq ft. Besides this boom in real estate, there has been a significant upturn in lodgings, with residents building a second floor and renting it to tourists, adding a new source of passive income for them. Societal welfare for the common man in Ayodhya has never been higher.

In preparation for the expected surge of tourists to Ayodhya, the hospitality, travel, and tourism industry has generated around 20,000 new jobs. Officials in the sector anticipate the creation of numerous positions, including roles in hospitality management, restaurant and hotel staff, logistics management, and drivers, towards the end of this year or the first half of 2025. The demand-supply dynamics will be closely monitored by hotel companies and restaurant owners, not only in Ayodhya but also in neighbouring cities like Lucknow, Kanpur, Gorakhpur, etc.

As for the businessmen, a survey from trade associations across 30 cities in different states shows that business worth Rs 1 lakh crore is expected to be generated thanks to the consecration ceremony, as per the Confederation of All India Traders (CAIT). The market has capitalised on this opportunity in every way possible. Apps like Blinkit, Swiggy Instamart, BB Now and Zepto are pushing 'pooja essentials' like diyas, flowers, fruits, sweets and idols through separate categories on their apps. Reliance Industries' consumer arms has taken measures to promote its Campa soft drinks, Alan's Bugles snacks and Independence line of products. Dabur has tied up with dhabas on highways of Uttar Pradesh to help push its Hajmola brand and has taken other measures to play up its hair oil and tea products.

THE RAM TEMPLE ECONOMY



Gautam Adani-led Adani Wilmar has tied up with dhabas and is pushing its Fortune brand through over 100 hoardings and kiosks, and around ten snack shops.

All of this amalgamates into an additional Rs 20,000-25,000 crore in tax revenue in FY25 for the Uttar Pradesh government, as per an SBI Research report.

Temples and development are traditionally seen as mutually exclusive but the making of the Ram Mandir at Ayodhya has proved that they can actually be mutually inclusive. The Ram temple is not just about religion, but business and economy too.



05 *LIVE LIFE QUEEN LIKE*

- Hritik Bhageria

What do we understand from the statement “Live Life King Size”? Live comfortably, do what makes you happy and don’t worry about anything around you. Now let’s slightly change this statement. **LIVE LIFE QUEEN LIKE.** Hmm... sounds interesting, but what does this notion mean? To start with, let’s go back to the Treta Yuga, to the days of Ram Rajya.

Bhagavan Ram had just arrived in Ayodhya after visiting Mithila. His return filled everyone with excitement and joy, and everyone was awaiting the arrival of their new queen, Mata Sita. Her presence filled the air with calmness and everyone was stunned by her beauty and humility. Happiness had found its way into Ayodhya and the people had no intention of letting it go. Everything was going perfectly for Mata Sita. But as the saying goes, “all things - good or bad, must one day come to an end”.

The cunning words Manthara had whispered into the ears of Mata Kaikeyi succeeded in influencing Kaikeyi to ask for the two boons that Raja Dasharath had granted her. The first one being the coronation of Bharata as king of Ayodhya, and the second being Ram’s exile for 14 years. Raja Dasharath was heartbroken, but Bhagavan Ram happily accepted by saying just a few words,

**रघुकुल रीत सदा चली आई,
प्राण जाए पर वचन न जाई ।**

Shri Ram was ready to leave for his exile but Mata Sita requested him to allow her to accompany him. Bhagavan Ram refused saying that she could enjoy all the comforts of Ayodhya and did not need to struggle in the forest. Mata Sita smiled and answered, “Ayodhya is nothing for me without my Ram”. She was ready to live a life of severe hardships rather than living a life without him.



She went to the forest with Shri Ram and lived her life happily, until she was deceived and abducted by the Rakshasa king, Ravana. The grandeur and opulence of Ravana’s empire reminded her of the beauty of Ayodhya. Although she was forced to live far away from Bhagavan, she still didn’t lose hope and always thought that her Ram was on his way.

Her long wait was finally over. Bhagavan Ram killed Ravana and brought back joy to his beloved's life. The entirety of Ayodhya was gaily decorated and the city celebrated the end of Bhagavan's 14 years of exile. But as the saying goes, "Not every story has a happy-ending".



People started questioning the purity of Mata Sita as she had spent a whole year in Lanka. This further gave rise to questions about the identity of the women of Ayodhya. Disparities and discrimination peaked as men started treating women in a disrespectful manner. Change was required in Ayodhya and women had to regain their position in society. That was when Mata Sita made the decision that she would live in exile until women gained their respect back and would make sure that she trained her children to fight for what is right. This decision separated Shri Ram and Mata Sita for years, again. Mata Sita took shelter in Maharishi Valmiki's ashram and taught her children, Luv and Kush, every quality that she saw in Shri Ram. Years passed and finally the people of Ayodhya started respecting women giving them what they deserved.

From this story, we don't just get a look at the triumph of Shri Ram over Ravana, but also learn to live our life in such a way that our actions change the perspective of the world and the people in it. Mata Sita teaches us that no matter how comfortable and powerful a life you live, to bring about a change, you will have to struggle, work hard and most importantly, make sacrifices.

06 *Voices Left Unheard*



- Bhavika Bazaz

We are always lazy and stubborn, they say. We are passive, I agree, to an extent. But what about those who speak and who are enthusiastic? We shut them down, don't we? I know her, beaming with energy, yet she is always neglected.

I know her, full of thoughts and potential, yet terrified to have a voice because of you dear loud and proud. She is not scared of speaking; she is terrified of not being heard by people like you. She is terrified of knowing that her voice won't find a home in your ears.

I remember feeling what she felt every single day when she spoke up. I remember it way too clearly because I saw it too. I saw her picking up your words and trying to fit them into her jigsaw puzzle because she had lost the confidence to even try to put her own puzzle together. She started to believe that her pieces were broken and crushed. When her creation was replaced with yours in her own puzzle, she was lost and confused.

She was stuck in a puzzle, one that she knew all too well but at the same time didn't. She doubted her heart and her potential. I don't know for sure if what she believed was true, but I would never figure it out, I would never want to.

For the first time ever, I would not want to believe. I would not want to believe that she was robbed. I would not want to believe that she lost her game to you. Amidst all that disbelief, I still hope that there is a place for both of . I still hope that there is a world where we both can co-exist.

I suppose all you can do is hear, but people like you, people of 'great power', shouldn't they know how to listen? People like you are everywhere yet, there are many like her too. You're not a majority but, we are not the minority either. However, no one seems to work together. Do you know why? Because it's easy to say. It's almost too easy to say that they're passive and that we're scared. There are conflicts and yes, we are at fault too. But why can't we just share our pieces and stop dividing them and crushing them? Why can't we make our shared puzzles with a completely new perspective to make the whole world look better?

07 #CIRS Impact 1.0

To be continued in Issue 15....

- Editorial Team



Q1) If there was one thing that you could tell your fifth grade self, what would it be?

Haardhik: Be more social. I entered as a bookworm and stayed one for a very long time.

Ankita: It'll get better as time goes on.

Thanusha: I've been here for 12 years, and I couldn't agree more with Ankita.

Aditya: I wouldn't say anything to my old self. I'd like to experience it all over again.

Thriambakesh: I would tell my younger self to curate my company in life.



Q2) Is there anything in your life that is 100% CIRS?

Unanimously: Our personalities! The way we interact with those around us has definitely been shaped by CIRS. Also, this school has the skill of turning everyone who studies here into a MASTER procrastinator.

Aditya: Quizzing. I remember, one Saturday Swarna Ma'am came and told me, "You should come and join the quiz club during movie time." After that, I started pursuing quizzing as a hobby, and it has helped in my contemporary career choices.

Ankita: The ability to sleep for 3 hours at night and still be happy the next morning.

Thanusha: The realization of the fact that FRIENDS are FAMILY. This school has developed our social skills.



Q3) What is the first thing that you would do if you came back?

Thriambakesh: I would go to the Mukundalaya box room and search for the spot where we signed our names.

Haardhik: I would love to interact with senior students and give them a glimpse of life after CIRS.

Aditya: I would like to return and see what has not changed. (and if Saji Bhaiya is still there...)



Q4) What would be one thing that you would say to a fifth grader right now?

Ankita: Just hang in there.

Thanusha: Socialize. Open yourself to others. They'll be the ones you'll spend the best time of your life with.

Aditya: Identify your talents and work upon them.

Thriambakesh: Don't be a goody-two-shoes.

Haardhik: Don't lose interest in what makes you, YOU!



08 *Beyond the Game*

Sports at CIRS - Krish Modi (Senior Sports Secretary)



It's an honor and a delightful trice where the exuberant sportsmen and women of CIRS pave a scintillating path of their remarkable journey in sporting excellence. Their victories are not only personal triumphs but collective victories for CIRS, which leave a spark of determination, persistence and inspiration in other students who aspire for the same goals. Let's take a look at the commendable achievements of our students in various sports fields.

The highlight of the year was the All India Chinmaya Khel Mela Athletic Meet, conducted in Chennai in Nehru Stadium. Various Chinmaya schools from all over the country participated in this athletic meet comprising of around 757 participants. Our school athletes participated with immense enthusiasm and through their sheer dedication and hardwork brought laurels to the school by securing 5 gold medals, 6 silver medals, 2 bronze medals and 1 Individual Championship won by Manisha R of grade 10. Our school stood 2nd overall amongst 32 other schools with over 91 points.



Our school swimmers also proved their limitless talent and skills by achieving marvellous feats in the Sahodaya Swimming Competition. Our school stood 3rd overall in the Boys and Girls category by clinching 13 gold medals, 10 silver medals and 12 bronze medals in both categories. After this they were still determined to achieve more and participated in the CBSE southzone swimming competition. Among 450 schools and around 3000 participants, our school's under-16 girls relay team bagged 2nd place in their event and were selected for the national level meet in which they stood 11th in their category.

It's a common saying that team spirit is what holds and binds us together. This indeed was showcased by many of the CIRS students who excelled in various sports with their team, by their team and for their team. In the academic year 2023-24, CIRS witnessed achievements in numerous team sports including football, basketball and throwball.

Our school's under-16 boys football team, with commendable sportsmanship and camaraderie, secured the 3rd position in the 1st Nathan Memorial Trophy, in which Aadi Jain of grade 10 earned the best goalkeeper title for his exceptional goalkeeping skills. The same team emerged as the winners in the 44TH Coimbatore Sahodaya Interschool Football Tournament in which Jayavardhan Singh Bhati of grade 10 received the best player award.

Our school's basketball team also portrayed an unwavering performance in the Sahodaya Interschool Basketball Tournament by achieving prizes in all the categories. The Under-16 and 19 Girls team secured the 3rd place, the under-19 Boys team bagged the 4th place and the under-16 Boys emerged as the Runners Up in the tournament.

The Girls under-14 and 19 throwball teams participated in the Sahodaya Throwball Tournament and succeeded in reaching the quarter and the semi-finals with each other's support and the spirit to work as a team.



A massive shoutout to all the CIRS champs! Here's to unlocking your inner sports superstar and scoring big victories in the years ahead. Remember, it only takes your all-out effort, and sports will show you what you're truly made of. So, lace up those shoes and get ready to bring your A-game!

09 *The Illusion of Fear*

IPSC Winning Speech - Raahi Tejas Shah

This year, CIRS had the honor of participating in the International Public Speaking competition, a prestigious event held under the auspices of the English Speaking Union (ESU). The ESU was established with the belief that effective communication between nations would lead to improved global understanding and ultimately, world peace. This belief endures today, with 54 international English-Speaking Unions spanning the globe from Albania to Yemen. In partnership with the Chinmaya Mission Chennai, the ESU selected the Indian Representative for 2024. Among 22 Zonal finalists, Raahi Tejas Shah from IB 1st year claimed the first position, surpassing older participants aged 16-20. Raahi's victory was an exceptional achievement given his age. We are happy and proud to present Raahi Tejas's final speech.

Speech Begins : Ladies and gentlemen, Namaste. Lo and behold! Perhaps the most unassuming invention known to mankind - an ordinary rope.

Oh, I have no doubt that you might see this as just another random everyday object. But to me, it is the epitome of a weighty philosophical thought which anchors the timeless wisdom of my country - Bharat.

Let's imagine; take a moment and think! What if this was a six-foot-long snake? What if I were to throw this at you without a moment's notice? An instant surge of fear barges in. A person once bitten by a snake will be scared of every rope. Yet, one must indeed wonder - is it really the circumstances or our web of perceptions which often send shivers down our spine? Dear fear fighters, I present to you a most fantastic friend and often a formidable foe - Fear.

Through the chapters of my childhood, two shades haunted my dreams: My father, and the dread of speaking before an audience.

Every time I was put on stage, I'd sprint away, haunted by fear. I thought I would be a disappointment and I thought I would fail. But I wasn't alone. Studies indicate that Glossophobia - the fear of public speaking - haunts 15-30% of the general population. It all boils down to one meager word - THOUGHT. I thought I would disappoint and fail; my thinking labeled public speaking as bad, and this sent any idea of speaking down the dreary abyss of negativity.



An interesting experiment was conducted that involved inducing fear through a 6-foot-long real snake! Surprisingly, Eleonora Gullone shared in her clinical review children under 2 years of age showed no signs of fear. The psychological review by O' Hebb further explained that in every experience, a certain kind of prerequisite is definitely involved in the process of feeling afraid.

Those innocent minds knew not the peril a snake could pose. Ignorance, in this instance, was bliss - the naïve children hadn't categorized a snake as good, or bad and so no thinking accounted for no fear. Only thinking of something as good or bad makes us fear it.

The brain weighs around 1.5 kg - about the same mass as a cauliflower. Only 2% of our body mass and yet it consumes 20% of our body's energy. We command a staggering 86 billion nerve cells and we have the freedom to think of whatever we like... yet we still choose to see opportunities through the lens of fear. We think of the judgment, the embarrassment, and the rejection we might face. Again, we have the freedom to think whatever we like. It's as though you are given all the 32 flavors of Baskin Robbins, and you still choose mint.

This fear of ours has been a companion ever since the age of early humans. At the time fear was perceived to be good. It was excellent at keeping us alive, it tells you, "DANGER! DO NOT ATTEMPT!"

Unfortunately, fear hasn't evolved as much as we have. The 86 billion cells still saw danger on the stage, and told me not to attempt. But if I listened to that and we did not attempt, I doubt humans would have come so far and I wouldn't be here on this stage. Fear itself is neither good nor bad, our thinking makes it appear such in the case of survival and an obstacle.

Robert Pattinson or as we know him 'The Batman' shared that he used to get "Paralyzed with anxiety" and "Just couldn't do anything for years". Pattinson explains "The only thing that ever worked was to just use that anxiety as a charge"

We have the same choice. Robert Pattinson had the choice of changing how we look at fear, the same choice that I took 3 years ago, the same choice that brought me to this stage. The same choice that makes this a rope and not a snake. It is the choice of thought that makes it optimistic or fearful, and it is the choice of thought that makes it good or bad.



Crossbusters

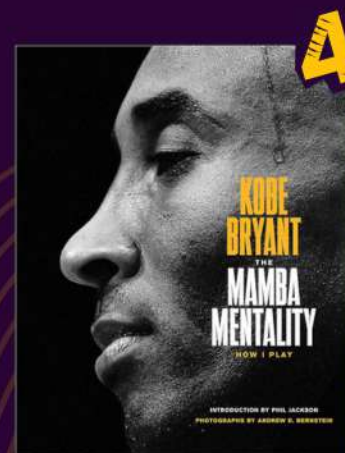
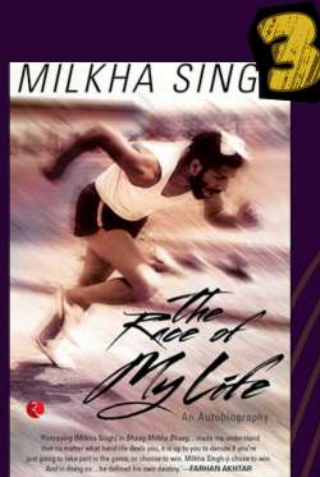
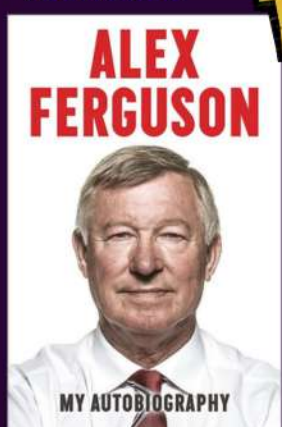


Our recommendations to keep you engrossed during your break!

Movies:



Books:



10 Facing Fallacies

Trailblazing with TOK

- Kavya Vishnu



We all enjoy debates and discussions, and as a result, we come across some statements or claims that have very weak foundations. Alternatively, we might be the ones being shot down due to a flaw in our own claims. The most serious threat to the integrity of an argument is insufficient or inaccurate information, but even with adequate material to support it, an argument can fail due to structural flaws and fraudulent strategies.

Suppressed, ignored, or overlooked in debates? Allow me to provide you with knowledge in this brief article, about a few of these common logical fallacies that you commit.

'Begging the question' is sometimes considered a synonym for 'Circular reasoning'. It treats matters under debate as already established. For instance, saying something like, "Robots are better leaders because they have superior leadership skills" is merely restating the thesis without offering any convincing arguments or supporting data. Circular reasoning is bad in arguments because of its blankly unproductive nature. They lead nowhere and only seem to put certain questions beyond questioning. This fallacy often occurs when someone assumes the truth of their conclusion in their premise, creating a never-ending loop of reasoning. It is important to be aware of this logical error in order to avoid being misled or convincing others with faulty arguments.



A false dichotomy is the fallacious presentation of two possibilities as the only two possibilities. In many scenarios, there are only two outcomes. For example, claims such as "Everyone must either consume food or die; a battery terminal is either negative or positive." However, quite often, there are other possibilities or shades of grey that are overlooked in a false dichotomy. This fallacy can be used to manipulate others by limiting their options and forcing them to choose between two extremes. It is crucial to critically analyse arguments and consider all possible alternatives before accepting a false dichotomy as the only truth.

A red herring is a commonly used tactic in debates and discussions. It involves diversion of attention away from the main issue at hand by introducing an unrelated or irrelevant topic. This tactic is often employed to confuse or mislead the audience, making it difficult for them to focus on the real argument being presented. For example, during a political debate, a candidate may bring up a controversial social issue as a red herring to distract the audience from discussing their economic policies. By shifting the focus onto an unrelated topic, they attempt to avoid scrutiny and avoid addressing their own potentially unpopular stances on economic matters. It is important to recognise red herrings and stay focused on the main point in order to have a productive and meaningful discussion.

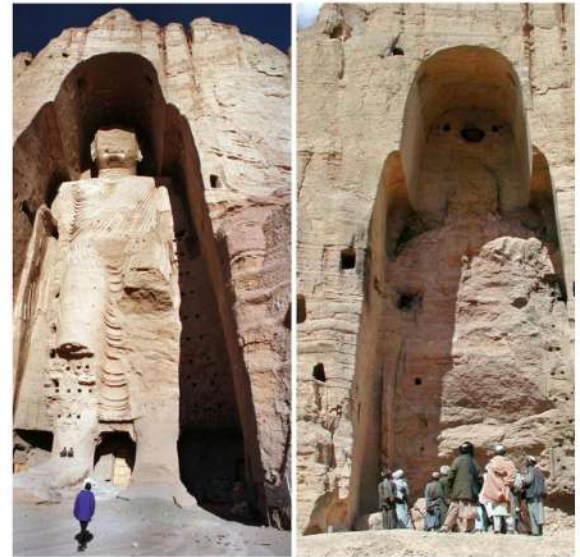
These are only a few examples of typical fallacies in conversations. Look at the many additional biases and logical fallacies that individuals regularly make to strengthen your perspectives and arguments. Knowing these fallacies allows you to recognise them in talks and debates and guarantee that your arguments are solid. Ultimately, understanding logical fallacies aids in critically evaluating arguments, fostering a more thoughtful approach to debates, thereby improving discussion quality, and increasing the likelihood of reaching a fair and well-informed conclusion.

Bharat, the linchpin of the ancient world, stands as a testament to the enduring legacy of a rich civilizational heritage which has successfully survived the test of time. The term 'Sanskriti,' denoting culture, encapsulates the essence of Bharat. As we embark on the journey through time, exploring India's vibrant cultural heritage, we witness a renaissance, a resurgence, which is breathing life into the very soul of the nation.

In this land of a billion people, a medley of cultures, traditions, and customs co-exist harmoniously. It's a unique drapery where different identities seamlessly merge into a singular grand narrative. The principle of 'Unity in Diversity' is not just a philosophical concept; it's deeply entrenched in the very soul of our Civilization – 'Vasudaiva Kutumbakam'.

Described as 'Manav Dharma' or 'Human Culture,' Bharat's identity transcends borders, resonating with a universal appeal for mutual respect and coexistence. Our civilization has always been an enlightened force, projecting a vibrant soft power inheritance through the annals of history. Our optimistic vision of a pluralistic governance system rooted in timeless civilizational ideals of Bharat has historically captivated the entire world.

As one of the world's oldest civilizations, India's cultural heritage constitutes the single most important source of its position as a potential superpower. The nation's cultural richness has fascinated outsiders since time immemorial, with invading armies plundering temples in attempts to erase India's deep-rooted traditions. Recent efforts by the Taliban in Afghanistan echo similar attempts to erase the traditional Afghani ethos.



Fortunately, the people of today's Bharat understand that our Nation's journey to becoming a future superpower must be guided by its rich cultural ethos. A famous adage holds that 'a nation stays alive when its culture stays alive,' and India's cultural resurgence is poised to breathe new life into its being. Bharat has been restoring places of cultural significance. The emphasis on the 'rejuvenation and rebirth' of cultural and pilgrimage sites is more than a restoration project; it's a vision to instill a sense of nationalism and pride among the people. This cultural revival is not just about correcting historical wrongs committed during the rule of outside invaders. It's about recognizing the role of sacred temples and sites in India's long and sustained civilizational struggle. Efforts to develop the Kashi Vishwanath Temple Corridor, build the Omkareshwar Dham or even the Somnath project are clear indicators of Bharat's commitment to reaching the pinnacle of success while standing proudly with its cultural identity.



A great man once said 'India cannot be India again until the temples again become alive. The whole alchemy of India lay in her temples; India received everything through her temples.' The spirit of cultural renaissance is nowhere more definite than in India. The journey of preserving the nation's culture, history, and art has taken a new shape in the last decade.

This cultural revival is crucial not only for India but also for positioning the country as a valuable contributor to the peaceful co-existence of ethnicities across the world.

The philosophy of 'Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam' (the world is one family) is successfully integrated into India's foreign policy initiatives. The promotion of ancient culture has proved helpful in mobilizing non-resident Indians and furthering India's interests on the global stage as a soft power.

Campaigns to spread awareness of historical remains, bringing back stolen Indian artifacts, and global advocacy at UNESCO symbolize India's quest to regain its rightful place in the global order as the birthplace of one of the oldest cultures and civilizations. Efforts extend beyond Indian territory. The redevelopment of Lord Sri Krishna Shrinath ji temple in Manama, Bahrain, and the foundation stone laying of the first Hindu temple in Abu Dhabi by the Indian Prime Minister strengthen bilateral ties with other countries. Similarly, the operationalization of Kushinagar airport gives impetus to India's Buddhist circuit tourism project, attracting devotees from around the world.



This reflects the beginning of a new era of thought – exploring the relationship between faith and development. Bharat is showing the world that development need not mean necessarily distancing oneself from culture. From rebuilding temples to building pucca homes, Bharat is driving a multifaceted and multifarious style of progress. No nation can think of becoming a world power by abandoning its civilizational and cultural ethos and foundations. This new mission for India's cultural renaissance is poised for success. Its impact shall be reflected in improved quality of life of different communities and the opening of brand-new frontiers based on art, culture, and history.

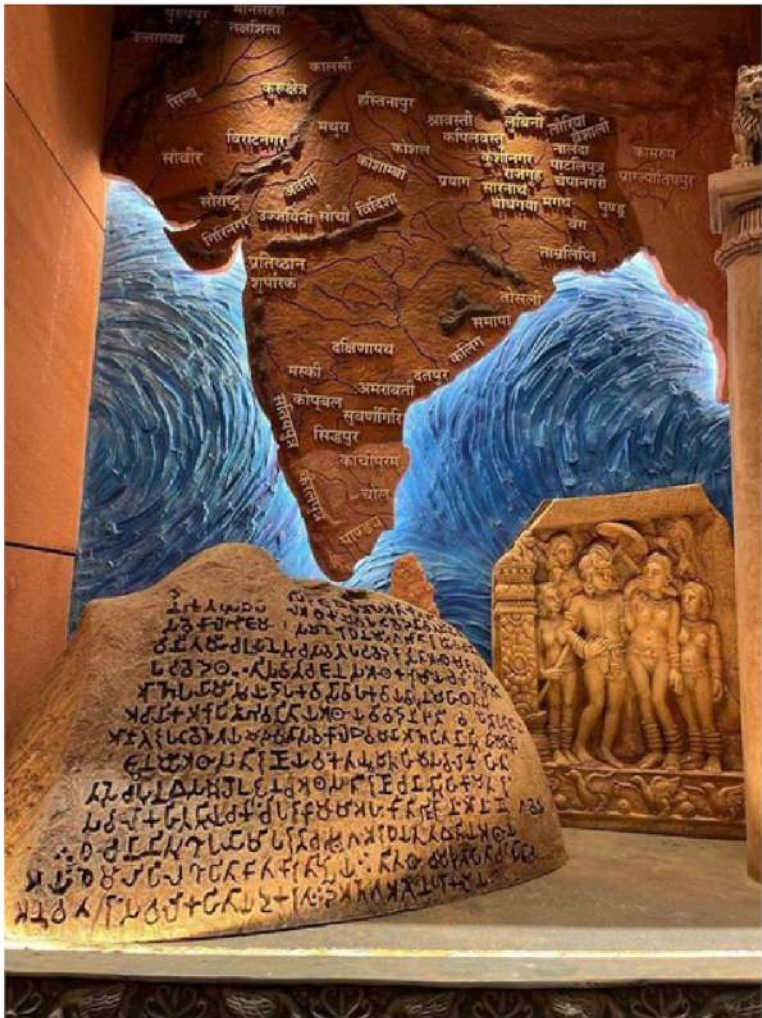
An excellent example of the historical and civilizational foundations on which the above thought-process has evolved is offered by noted historian Kalidas Nag in his essay on 'Indian Internationalism.' Written in 1922, the essay was presented at the prestigious Peace Congress of Lugano in Switzerland and re-published in the first edition of the journal produced by the Greater India Society which researched ancient India's foreign policy footprints.

Nag's essay begins in the 14th Century BC with the warring Hittite and Mitanni tribes of Cappadocia (Turkey) invoking the Vedic gods, Mitra, Varuna, and Indra to formulate a peace treaty, and the twin-gods Nasatyas to bless a matrimonial alliance. Nag presents this event, recorded in the ancient Boghaz Keui inscription, as the earliest evidence of India's internationalism that focused on peace-making and spiritual unity.

He also mentions Emperor Ashoka's "new world of constructive politics" guided by the "philosophy of conquest by righteousness (dharma-vijaya)" and emerged as a "spiritual oasis." The Hindu-Buddhist civilizational compact, as established by Ashoka, emerges as a key point in Nag's vision of India's internationalism.

On similar lines, the current efforts by Bharat aim at ushering in a new unapologetic cultural nationalism deeply rooted in the Bharatiya Civilizational Ethos. Efforts to revive India's Cultural Unity include initiatives like Kashi Tamil Sangamam. It is an effort to bridge centuries of cultural divide between the North and South of India, creating a unique platform to rediscover and integrate ancient knowledge and cultural heritage with modern thought, philosophy, and technology.

The PRASHAD scheme launched by the Ministry of Tourism in 2014-15 aims at the development of pilgrimage destinations. The Ek Bharat Shrestha Bharat program actively enhances interaction between people of different states promoting greater understanding and cohesion.



Swadesh Darshan and Swadesh Darshan 2.0 focus on developing theme-based tourist circuits and revving up destination tourism with a dharmic twist. The Buddha Circuit, Heritage Circuit, Sufi Circuit, Krishna Circuit, and Tirthankar Circuit are examples of these efforts

The Kashi Mahakal Express, a Bhagavan Shiva-themed train, connects places related to three jyotirlingas, Bharat SHRI, aiming at the preservation of India's ancient inscriptions, plans to set up Bharat Shared Repository of Inscriptions (SHRI) in a Digital Epigraphy Museum in Hyderabad.



This is just the tip of the iceberg, from tourism to the Kumbh Mela, Bharat is growing in leaps and bounds with religious tourism employing around 40 million people and contributing significantly to the nation's economy.

The construction of the Ram Temple in Ayodhya is not just a spiritual endeavor; it is an economically viable option. The region stands to benefit from the development of infrastructure, job creation, and a real estate boom. The government's allocation of ₹500 crore for the construction of an airport in Ayodhya is a step towards enhancing connectivity and boosting the local economy.

Temples, as representatives of India's rich heritage, symbolize the nation's strong links with its past. Temples are not just places of worship; they are repositories of history, with inscriptions, sculptures, murals, carvings, and architecture.



The Ram Mandir in Ayodhya is not only a religious monument it is a symbol of indigenous reclamation. It's perhaps the greatest de-colonial architecture currently in the world. A symbol of hope against indigenous oppression, segregation and conversion. Ram Mandir acts as a clarion call to indigenous communities across the world that it is possible to safe guard our indigenous way of life. It is possible to stand strong against colonial harassment and it is possible to win after 500 years.

Hindus have proven their resilience; this is the re-awakening of an indigenous community which has slumbered under the yoke of colonization. With the rise of Ayodhya, we see the rise of Bharat. Such initiatives for the rejuvenation and restoration of cultural and pilgrimage sites are well-poised to re-instill a sense of ownership of the indigenous cultural identities.



The 'I - ness' of Bharat's civilization has found a new anchor. This cultural renaissance isn't just a restoration project; it's a journey to revive the spirit that defines the nation's essence.

Captures

@CIRS







CREATIVE CORNER



Naïtik A. ~ IX 🏆



Kanisha ~ X 🏆



Sarvi S. ~ IX 🏆



Mridul M. ~ X 🏆



V. Manassa - IB I 🏆



Vaidehi M. ~ X 🏆



M. Siddarth & Abhinav R. ~ VII



Seyon ~ VII



Vivaan J. ~ X



Dhruthi ~ IX

भारत माता

तेरे बिना कुछ नहीं,
तेरे संग सब कुछ है,

तू माँ है मेरी,
तू जान मेरी,
तेरे बिन मेरा कुछ
नहीं।

तू ढाल मेरी,
आन-बान-शान तू ही,
तू माँ मेरी।

तुझे सलाम करूंगा,
तेरा नाम जपूंगा,
धर्म जात भूलकर,
तेरा स्वर्णिम इतिहास रचूंगा।

क्योंकि तू माँ है मेरी,
क्योंकि तू जान मेरी,
तुझ ही से जन्मा,
तेरे लिए निपटने की ठान ली।

तेरे वास्ते सब हासिल कर,
या फिर कर कुर्बान,
तेरा परचम रहेगा महान।

किस्मतवालों की माँ है तू,
किस्मतवालों की जान है तू,
किस्मतवालों का सर्वस्व है तू।

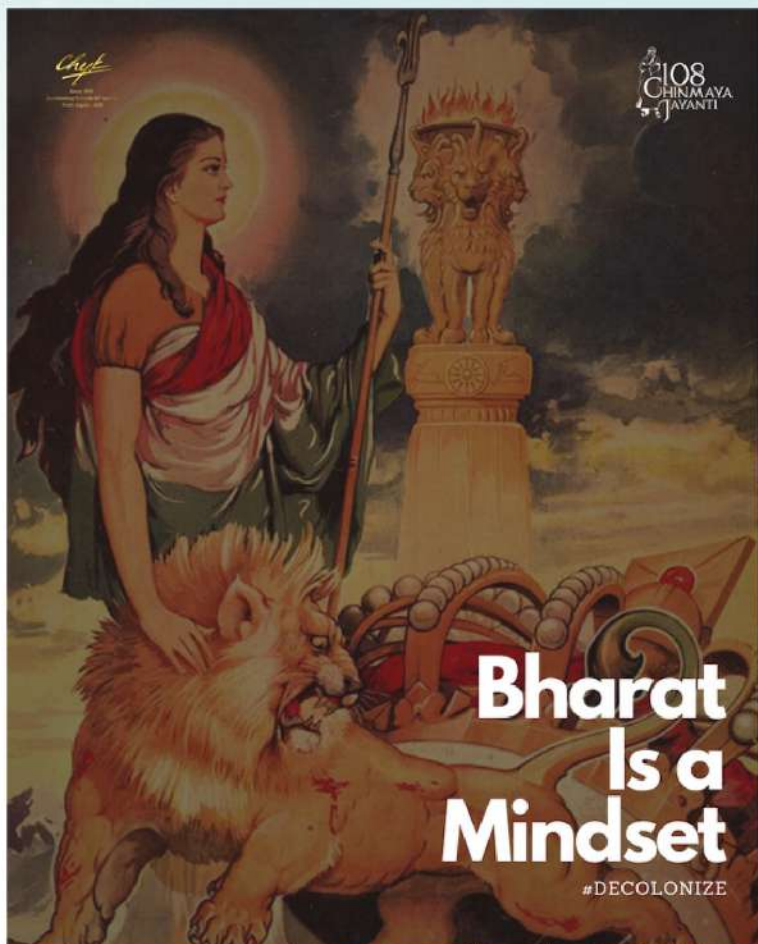
तेरे कण-कण से बहती है करुणा,
श्रापित हो या अजय सब करते तेरी रमना,
लाख अक्षर असक्षम अगर करूँ तेरा वर्णन।

ऐसी है माँ मेरी,
ऐसी है जान मेरी,
ऐसा ही है मेरा सब कुछ।

लेखक: अमोघ अगर्वल (Amogh Agarwal) ~ VIII

The only thing that can bring us together is our respect for and reverence to our distinct National Culture - Swami Chinmayananda

February 2023 | Re-Think, Re-Align & Re-Boot your Identity



#De-Colonize - 'We need a class of people who will serve as interpreters between us and those we seek to govern.. they will be Indian in blood and colour but British in their tastes, Morals and Opinions' Said a Man who Massacred the Indigenous Education Systems of this Civilization.

Bharat is a mindset which aims to create the opposite of the same. Bharat is a mindset which seeks resurgence, revival and revolution of the current world order #DeColonize

Reflection -

- Are you a Bharatiya ?
- What do you value the most in your life ?
- Do you hold a strong connection to your national identity, and what actions do you take to strengthen and cultivate this identity?

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